

CHESS AND OTHER BOARD GAMES



BOTH CHILDREN AND ADULTS enjoy games, whether for the challenge of perfecting a skill, the excitement of competition, or simply for fun.

Board games, in which competing players move pieces on a special board following rules agreed in advance, are particularly popular. They have a long history, and exist in every culture. They range from demanding games of skill and strategy, such as the ancient game of chess, to more simple games of chance, like snakes and ladders, where a throw of the dice determines the winner.

Strategy games

Games of strategy are challenging, for superior skill, concentration, and tactics decide the winner. Chance plays no part. In most strategy games two players aim to cross the board, or to encircle or capture their opponent's pieces.



Go
Go, also known as *wei-chi*, is at least 4,300 years old. It is extremely popular in China, Japan, and Korea. Players capture areas of the board by surrounding them with their own pieces.

Chess

Chess is a war-game. Two players aim to capture, or take, the other's pieces, ultimately trapping the opponent's king. This situation, known as checkmate, occurs when the king cannot be protected by his own pieces, and cannot move without being taken. The word checkmate comes from the Persian *shah-mat* (the king is dead). Chess can be enjoyed at all levels: by beginners, or contested by grandmasters in international competition.

The board has 64 squares.

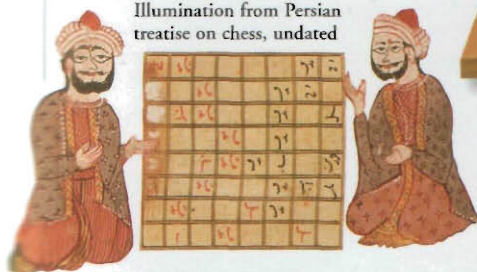


Each player starts with 16 pieces.



Kasparov plays the computer

Illumination from Persian treatise on chess, undated



History of chess

It is thought that chess originated in China or India more than 1,400 years ago. It spread to North Africa and was introduced to Europe after the Muslim conquest of Spain. Early pieces were based on an Asian army, with elephants, chariots, and footsoldiers.

Pieces

Chess pieces consist of eight pawns, two bishops, knights, and rooks (castles), a king, and a queen. Each piece has its distinctive moves: pawns, for instance, can only move one space forward, while the queen can move in any direction, as far as is needed.

Computer chess

Computers can be programmed to play chess against humans. In 1997, the chess world was shocked when a supercomputer beat the Russian world champion Gary Kasparov (b.1963) in a match. A vast memory for the tactics of past games gives computers an edge.

Race games

Many board games are races, where the winner is the first player to reach a certain part of the board or remove all their pieces. Some race games depend on luck, when a throw of the dice decides how quickly a player moves. This allows players of different ages or levels to compete fairly against each other.



Starting position for mancalah

Mancalah

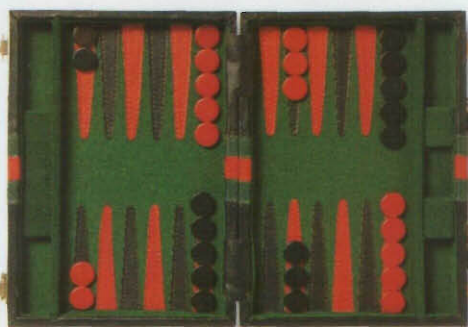
There are many varieties of this ancient game of skill from Africa. Two or more players compete to clear their side of the board. Each takes turns to pick up a pile of pebbles, dropping them one by one in the hollows.

Pachisi

In India, pachisi is a popular game. Four players race counters around a cross-shaped board; they throw dice or shells to see how many spaces to move. Many other games, such as ludo, are based on pachisi.



Men playing pachisi in India.



Starting position for backgammon

Backgammon

Invented 5,000 years ago in Asia, backgammon is a fast-paced game for two players. It draws on both skill and chance, and is most popular around the Mediterranean. The first player to remove all his or her "men" from the board wins.

Playing cards

Card games do not need a special board, but must be played on a flat surface. Generally, games are for two or four players. Some games, such as bridge, require concentration and skill, and are played at international competition level; games such as poker, which rely more on luck, are often played by gamblers for money.

A pack of cards contains 52 cards, divided into four groups, known as suits.



Diamonds



Spades



Clubs

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